

General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Indian Theatre Forms



INDIAN THEATRE FORMS



Introduction

- Indian theatre is a **narrative art form** that combines **music, dance, and acting**.
- It involves **recitation, dance, and music** to convey stories and traditions.
- **Natya Veda** was created by Brahma, according to **Bharat Muni's Natya Shastra**, for the pastime of Gods.
- The **Natya Shastra** (200 BC – 200 AD) is the **first formal treatise on dramaturgy**, covering various plays and aspects of **classical Sanskrit literature**.

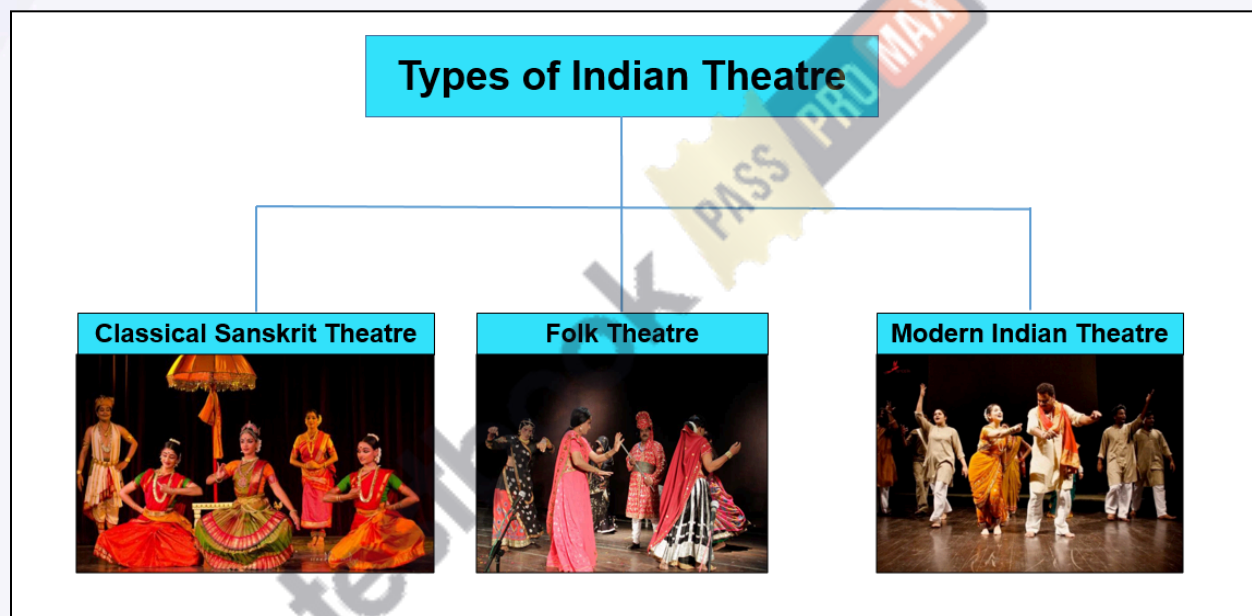
Origin of Theatre Forms in India

- The **Sanskrit theatre** was India's first classical theatre form, believed to have emerged after **Greek and Roman theatres**.
- **Alexander the Great's invasion** introduced Greek-style plays to India, influencing local theatre.

- Some scholars argue that Indian theatre predates Greek influence.
- Excavated sites like **Sitabena and Jogimara caves** are believed to be among the oldest **amphitheatres** in the world.

Features of Indian Theatre

- **Combination of acting, conversation, poetry, and music** in theatrical performances.
- Originated as a **narrative art form** to express local history and social values.
- Performed during **religious festivals, prayers, and community gatherings**.
- **A blend of entertainment and religious observance**.
- **Six elements of theatre: Plot, Character, Thought, Fiction, Music, and Spectacle**.



Classical Sanskrit Theatre

- The term '**Nataka**' originates from '**Nata**' meaning dancer in Sanskrit.
- Sanskrit plays are also referred to as **Rupaka, Drishyakavya, and Preksakavya**.
- **Two types of plays:**
 - **Lokadharmi:** Realistic depictions of everyday life.
 - **Natyadharmi:** Traditional plays with stylized storytelling and symbolism.
- **Notable Playwrights:**
 - **Kalidasa** (Abhijnanasakuntalam)

- **Ashvaghosha**
- **Vishakadatta**
- The decline of Sanskrit theatre occurred due to:
 - Shift towards **poetry**.
 - Arrival of **Muslim rulers**.
 - Rise of **folk theatre**.

Folk Theatre

- **Folk theatre** represents local **culture, beliefs, and practices**.
- It originated in **rural areas** and evolved with **devotional themes**.
- Over time, it incorporated **secular themes** like love ballads and stories of local heroes.
- Became a **tool for social awareness** post-independence.
- Examples of **Folk Theatre Forms**:
 - **Jatra** (Bengal)
 - **Bhavai** (Gujarat)
 - **Tamasha** (Maharashtra)
 - **Yakshagana** (Karnataka)
 - **Therukoothu** (Tamil Nadu)

Other Classification of Theatres:

Theatre Type	Name	State
Ritual Theatre	Ankia Naat	Assam
	Ramlila	Uttar Pradesh
	Raslila	Uttar Pradesh
	Bhuta	Karnataka
	Ramman	Uttarakhand
Theatre of Entertainment	Bhavai	Gujarat
	Daskathia	Odisha

	Garoda	Rajasthan
	Jatra	West Bengal
	Kariyala	Himachal Pradesh
	Maach	Madhya Pradesh
	Nautanki	Uttar Pradesh
	Oja-Pali	Assam
	Pandavani	Chhattisgarh
	Powada	Maharashtra
	Swang	Haryana
	Tamasha	Maharashtra
	Villu Pattu	Tamil Nadu
	Bhand Pather	Jammu & Kashmir
	Bhaona	Assam
	Dashavatar	Maharashtra
	Bhand	Jammu & Kashmir
South Indian Theatre	Yakshagana	Karnataka
	Burra Katha	Andhra Pradesh
	Pagati Veshaalulu	Andhra Pradesh
	Bayalata	Karnataka
	Tal-Maddale	Karnataka
	Theyyam	Kerala

	Krishna Attam	Kerala
	Kuruvanji	Tamil Nadu

Major Theatre Forms of States

State	Theatre Form	Features
Uttar Pradesh	Ramlila	Enacts the Ramayana, performed during Dussehra. Combines drama, music, and dance.
Uttar Pradesh	Nautanki	A folk theatre with exaggerated acting, music, and dance, often with social or romantic themes.
Uttar Pradesh	Raasleela	Based on Krishna-Radha's love stories, performed with music and dance.
Maharashtra	Tamasha	Semi-erotic folk theatre with Lavani dance and vibrant music.
Maharashtra	Powada	Ballads that narrate historical events, particularly valorous deeds.
Maharashtra	Dashavatar	Depicts the ten incarnations of Vishnu, using dance and drama.
West Bengal	Jatra	Open-air theatre focused on melodrama with musical interludes.
West Bengal	Putul Nach	String puppetry with wooden dolls, combining music and dance.
Assam	Bhaona	Created by Sankardeva, depicting religious themes, often Krishna's tales.
Assam	Oja-Pali	Narrative performance combining singing, dance, and storytelling.

Kerala	Koodiyattam	Ancient Sanskrit drama, performed with elaborate gestures and expressions.
Kerala	Theyyam	Ritualistic performance where performers embody gods, involving dance and music.
Kerala	Mudiyettu	Depicts the fight between Goddess Kali and the demon Darika.
Kerala	Krishnattam	Depicts the life of Krishna, influenced by Kathakali.
Karnataka	Yakshagana	Dance-drama blending music, dance, and dialogues, based on mythological stories.
Karnataka	Togalu Gombeyatta	Shadow puppetry using leather puppets to depict epics.
Karnataka	Bayalata	Open-air folk theatre enacting mythological themes with music and dance.
Karnataka	Tal-Maddale	A storytelling tradition with music, without elaborate costumes.
Tamil Nadu	Therukoothu	Street theatre performed during festivals, focusing on local legends and epics.
Tamil Nadu	Bommalattam	Large marionettes manipulated with strings and rods, narrating epics.
Gujarat	Bhavai	Folk theatre involving satire, often portraying social themes.
Rajasthan	Kathputli	String puppetry using wooden dolls dressed in traditional attire, accompanied by folk music.
Odisha	Daskathia	Narrative performance using singing and storytelling.
Odisha	Ravanachhaya	Shadow puppetry with puppets made from deer skin, focused on epics.

Haryana	Swang	A folk performance focusing on music and dance with humorous elements.
Himachal Pradesh	Kariyala	Performed during local festivals with comedic and social themes.
Chhattisgarh	Pandavani	Narrates tales from the Mahabharata with music and storytelling.
Goa	Dashavatar	Depicts the ten incarnations of Vishnu, performed with dance and music.
Jammu & Kashmir	Bhand Pather	Satirical folk theatre combining dance and drama, performed during festivals.
Andhra Pradesh	Burra Katha	Storytelling with music and rhythmic beats, narrating historical and mythological themes.
Andhra Pradesh	Pagati Veshaalulu	Traditional theatre combines music and humor, with rural themes.

Modern Indian Theatre

- **Modern theatre** in India emerged in the **18th century** under British influence.
- The introduction of **Western proscenium theatre** expanded beyond indigenous forms.
- **Bengali-language theatre** emerged in the **1830s**, supported by wealthy families.
- **Parsi theatres** (1850s-1920s) produced plays in **Gujarati and Marathi**, featuring **music and vibrant sets**.
- **Sangeet Natak Akademi (1952)**: Established to promote performing arts and theatre.
- **National School of Drama (NSD)**: Played a key role in training prominent theatre artists.

Major Developments in Modern Theatre

- Emergence of **regional theatre** in different languages.
- Revival of **traditional folk elements** in modern productions.
- Growth of **experimental theatre** with social and political themes.